

CS486 – Design Brief 2

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1 Overarching Question(s)

Our overarching question is: *How do young independent travelers make activity decisions during short leisure trips in unfamiliar cities, and why do current tools often fail to give them confidence that an option is right for them right now?*

More specifically, we want to understand whether the main difficulty is not finding options, but judging *contextual fit*: whether a place matches the traveler’s mood, energy, budget, time constraints, weather, and social situation in the moment.

Our persona hypothesis helps us test this problem across six contrasting profiles rather than treating young travelers as one homogeneous group. Lina, our primary persona, represents the center of the problem: budget-conscious, digitally dependent, traveling in a small group, and often overloaded when the group must decide what to do next. Tran lets us test whether the same difficulty remains in a simpler duo-travel setting. Kevin captures a highly social-media-driven and group-based planning style. Matteo helps us test whether the problem persists when budget matters less, but fatigue, convenience, and time loss matter more. Emma reveals distrust, verification habits, and what evidence a recommendation tool would need before users rely on it. Claire, as an adjacent non-user, helps define the boundary of the concept by showing when strong advance planning makes in-the-moment support less relevant.

Taken together, these profiles allow us to compare recurring behavior variables such as planning style, travel mode, source reliance, context sensitivity, decision confidence, and trust in recommendations.

1.1 Open-ended Exploratory Questions

- Can you tell me about a recent short trip where deciding what to do felt difficult?
- Walk us through one concrete moment, from the first idea to the final decision.
- What apps, websites, saved items, or people did you use, and in what order?
- What made you feel unsure, overloaded, or stuck?
- Can you recall a case where a place looked good online but turned out to be a poor fit in reality?
- What makes an option feel *worth it right now*, considering mood, energy, weather, time pressure, budget, or group preferences?
- When traveling with others, how do you move from many possible options to one shared choice?
- When you do not trust a recommendation immediately, what do you check next?
- For heavy planners: when do your trip decisions feel already “done” before departure?

1.2 Structured Questions

- On your last short trip, did you travel alone, with one other person, or in a group?
- Did you decide activities mostly before the trip, partly before and partly during, or mostly during the trip?
- Which sources did you use: social media, Google Maps, blogs, review sites, booking sites, friends, or other?
- Which factor mattered most in the final decision: budget, distance, time, energy, weather, vibe, reviews, or group preference?
- How often did you switch between apps before deciding?
- Did you save many options but still struggle to choose one?
- How confident did you feel in your final decision: low, medium, or high?
- How much do you trust recommendations from digital tools: low, medium, or high?
- Did the final choice feel better because it was popular, or because it fit the moment?

2 Ideas to Recruit and Interview Users

We would recruit around the six persona types rather than only by age.

Lina

For Lina, we would recruit master's students or young travelers who take short city trips with a small group of friends and are highly budget-conscious. Good channels would include student associations, group chats, Instagram stories, Erasmus circles, and friend networks. A café or informal campus setting would work well, especially if she can show saved TikToks, Instagram posts, Google Maps pins, and group messages.

Tran

For Tran, we would recruit young adults or master's students who usually travel with one friend and want to make efficient decisions without comparing too many options. This profile should rely more on maps and reviews than on social media. University networks, friends-of-friends, and travel-oriented student communities would be suitable channels. A quiet study space or remote call would fit this more practical decision style.

Kevin

For Kevin, we would recruit bachelor students who travel with friends, have a tight budget, and actively save places from TikTok or Instagram. Student chats, WhatsApp groups, Instagram stories, and friend networks would be effective. An informal and social setting would help us observe how saved content, screenshots, and group chats turn into group decisions.

Matteo

For Matteo, we would recruit young professionals through LinkedIn, alumni networks, coworking spaces, or colleagues who take short trips around work or long weekends. Evening or remote interviews would fit his context and help reveal trade-offs between effort, convenience, and whether something feels worth the time.

Emma

For Emma, we would deliberately recruit a hesitant user through prompts such as: “Do you double-check every travel recommendation before deciding?” She should ideally show how she cross-checks TikTok, Google Maps, blogs, and friends, since this can reveal trust barriers and evidence needs.

Claire

For Claire, we would recruit a working professional who plans almost everything in advance using booking sites, blogs, and saved lists. LinkedIn, travel-planning groups, and friends-of-friends would be suitable. She helps define the boundary of the concept by showing when in-the-moment support becomes less relevant.

3 Set Up of Interviews

We conducted six semi-structured interviews of about 45–60 minutes using one shared interview guide. The overall structure remained the same across participants, but we adapted the probes depending on each person’s planning style, trust level, and travel context. In each session, one team member led the interview while the other took notes, and we debriefed immediately afterward to compare observations and refine later interviews.

We distributed the workload by participant profile rather than equally. Nicolas led the more student-centered and trust-sensitive interviews, while Tuan led the more professionally established and boundary-case interviews. This allowed us to notice recurring patterns within different parts of the persona space while still discussing all six interviews together.

Aya (corresponding most closely to the Lina persona)

Aya was a 22-year-old master’s student in Communication Systems at EPFL. We interviewed her on 23 April 2026 from 16:10 to 17:00 in a café area near the Rolex Learning Center in Lausanne. Nicolas was the interviewer and Tuan the note-taker. Aya matched the Lina hypothesis closely: she takes short city trips with a small group of friends, is budget-conscious, plans partly in advance, uses TikTok and Instagram for ideas, and relies on Google Maps for practical checks. Her strongest contribution was to show that the key difficulty is not lack of options, but the need to choose one option that fits the group’s mood, time, energy, and budget in the moment. We therefore emphasized questions about group coordination, contextual fit, and how the group negotiates between attractive but impractical options. As observation material, she showed saved TikToks, Google Maps pins, and parts of a group chat from a recent trip.

Maya (corresponding most closely to the Tran persona)

Maya was a 25-year-old master’s student in Life Sciences Engineering at EPFL. We interviewed her on 24 April 2026 from 12:20 to 13:05 in a quiet study area on campus, with Nicolas as interviewer and Tuan as note-taker. She matched the Tran hypothesis: she usually travels with one friend, wants efficient decisions, dislikes excessive comparison, and relies more on maps and reviews than on social media. With her, we focused less on group negotiation and more on quick filtering, efficiency, and confidence in a duo-travel setting. The most revealing material came from asking how she narrows options without wasting time and what makes one option feel worth the effort. During the observation phase, she showed how she uses Google Maps and review platforms to reduce the choice set.

Daniel (corresponding most closely to the Kevin persona)

Daniel was a 22-year-old bachelor student in engineering at EPFL. We interviewed him on 24 April 2026 from 17:20 to 18:10 at the Rolex Learning Center café in Lausanne, with Nicolas as interviewer and Tuan as note-taker. He matched the Kevin hypothesis very well: he travels in a small group of friends, saves many places from TikTok and Instagram before the trip, and often changes plans once on site depending on mood, weather, queues, and what the group wants. His interview made the fragmented and social nature of the current process very visible. We emphasized questions about app switching, saved posts, screenshots, and group coordination. As observation material, he showed saved TikToks and group messages used during travel planning.

Luca (corresponding most closely to the Matteo persona)

Luca was a 28-year-old junior consultant based in Geneva. We interviewed him on 25 April 2026 from 19:05 to 19:55 via Zoom, with Tuan as interviewer and Nicolas as note-taker. He matched the Matteo hypothesis: he takes short trips around work and long weekends, is less constrained by price than students, but is very sensitive to fatigue, travel time, and whether something feels worth the effort. With him, we focused on convenience, time efficiency, and how travelers judge whether an option is worth it right now. His interview was especially useful for clarifying that the problem is not only budget, but also effort, friction, and low-energy moments.

Sofia (corresponding most closely to the Emma persona)

Sofia was a 24-year-old master’s student who also works part-time in retail. We interviewed her on 26 April 2026 from 15:40 to 16:30 in a quiet study room at EPFL, with Nicolas as interviewer and Tuan as note-taker. She matched the Emma profile most strongly: she likes discovering places, but distrusts recommendations and repeatedly cross-checks Google Maps, social media, blogs, and friends before committing. For Sofia, we focused more explicitly on hesitation, trust, and contradictions between sources. The most important probes asked what she checks when she does not trust a recommendation and what kind of explanation would make her trust one faster. During the observation phase, she demonstrated how she cross-checks places across apps.

Caroline (corresponding most closely to the Claire persona)

Caroline was a 35-year-old HR Business Partner based in Geneva. We interviewed her on 27 April 2026 from 18:35 to 19:25 via Google Meet, with Tuan as interviewer and Nicolas as note-taker. She matched the Claire profile: she plans most things before departure, uses booking sites, blogs, and saved lists, and is much less interested in spontaneous in-the-moment decisions. Her value was mainly as a contrast case. We emphasized questions about when a trip feels “already planned” before departure and what situations still force improvisation. She also showed the type of itinerary notes and saved planning materials she usually prepares in advance.

Comparison with our hypothesis table

Overall, Aya, Maya, Daniel, Luca, and Sofia aligned closely with the users we are most interested in designing for, but in different ways. Aya represented the central small-group and budget-sensitive version of the problem; Maya showed that the same difficulty can remain important even with only one friend and a more map-based process; Daniel captured the highly social-media-driven and collaborative side of planning; Luca highlighted convenience, fatigue, and “worth it right now”; and Sofia showed how strongly trust and verification shape decisions. Caroline was still useful to interview, but mainly as a boundary case. Her behavior does not

match the core problem our concept addresses, because she deliberately reduces uncertainty before the trip rather than during it.

These interviews also confirmed that adapting the guide was necessary. The most revealing material came from different probes for different participants: group overload and negotiation for Aya, efficient filtering for Maya, coordination and app-switching for Daniel, effort and convenience for Luca, trust and cross-checking for Sofia, and advance-planning boundaries for Caroline. This supports the idea that the guide should remain structured but flexible rather than being used as a rigid questionnaire.

4 Post interview analysis of results

Overall, the interviews largely validated the core insight from Design Brief 1, while also refining the role of trust, explanation, and concept boundary. Three findings stood out as especially surprising after the interviews and storyboard follow-up.

1. **The core problem was validated more strongly than expected: users do not mainly suffer from lack of ideas, but from overload when trying to turn many possibilities into one contextually right choice.** This appeared very clearly not only for Aya and Daniel, who save many ideas from TikTok and Instagram, but also for Maya and Luca, whose process is more map-based and practical. Even when the source mix changes, the same difficulty remains: there are often enough options, but not enough confidence about which one is worth the time, effort, money, and mood of the moment. This reinforces our main insight from Design Brief 1. It suggests that the design should not focus on generating even more recommendations, but on narrowing down options quickly and meaningfully.
2. **Trust emerged as a broader design requirement than we originally expected.** We initially associated distrust mainly with Emma-type users such as Sofia, but the interviews showed that explanation and justification matter much more widely. Sofia made this most explicit: she wants to know why an option is reliable, recent, and not just overhyped. However, Aya, Daniel, Maya, and Luca also all reacted positively to the storyboard specifically when the shortlist included reasons. In other words, explanation is not only a feature for hesitant users; it is part of what makes a recommendation usable at all. This shifts the design direction away from a black-box recommendation tool and toward a transparent support system that shows why an option fits now.
3. **The storyboard confirmed the general flow, but also revealed two important refinements: the interaction must stay lightweight, and the concept has a clear boundary.** Across Aya, Daniel, Maya, Luca, and Sofia, the general sequence from overload to filtering to shortlist felt realistic. However, users repeatedly warned that the tool must not add complexity through too many inputs or too much detail. They wanted concise, situationally relevant information such as distance, opening hours, expected effort, price level, atmosphere, and group suitability. At the same time, Caroline clarified the boundary of the concept. For her, the tool is useful only when the existing plan breaks down or an unexpected gap appears; it is not a replacement for advance planning. This means our concept should be designed primarily for semi-spontaneous in-trip decision-making, while still being able to act as a smart backup tool when plans fail.

Taken together, these findings suggest that our concept should be a lightweight, transparent, context-aware decision support tool that helps semi-spontaneous travelers narrow many possible options into a small justified shortlist.